there, reading all kinds of books. The bookshelves also had lots of little knickknacks. Her mother loved pretty things, and displayed them here along with the books. So there were beautiful pieces of pottery, dolls from wherever they had travelled, and of course wooden and clay animals and birds from all around the world.

Once Owlie was moved to the library, strict rules were laid down for everyone in the house. The two doors were never to be left open – not at night, not in the day. Every night, Payal would leave the cage door open and put a plate of mincemeat on top of the cage. This was so that when Owlie flew out of her cage, she could also learn to find her food.

Initially, Payal would shut the cage door every morning when she popped in to say hello to Owlie before going to school. She would always find Owlie on her perch inside the cage, though the cage door was still open. But Payal knew Owlie was flying because she found bits of meat all over the room. After some time, Payal stopped shutting the cage door even during the day. After all, people seldom went into that room all day, and Owlie was always asleep, so there seemed little point.

Every day when Payal came back from school, the first thing she did was to peep into the library. Usually, she would find Owlie fast asleep on her perch. But today, it was different. The cage was empty and there was no sign of Owlie! And the door to the garden was open.'Mom!' Payal howled. 'Who left the garden door open? How will we find Owlie now? 'Don't panic,' said Mom. 'She must be somewhere around.' They shut the garden door and looked in every corner of the room. Behind doors, on top of the tall bookshelves, in every nook and cranny. No Owlie.

Tears ran down Payal's cheeks. They had wanted Owlie to fly away, but not so soon. She was still so small, how would she hunt for her food? What if a kite or eagle swooped down on her? Finally, Mom said, 'Well, now Owlie has gone, we may as well leave the doors open and air the room.' Wiping her tears, Payal threw open the doors to the room. She hoped secretly that Owlie would come in if the doors were kept open.

Mom left the room to go do her afternoon errands. When she came back a couple of hours later, Payal was sitting, gazing mournfully at Owlie's cage.'Why don't you find yourself a good book to read?' Mom asked. She knew that reading a book was the only way Payal would cheer up. When Payal was sad, she always read.'Okay,' sighed Payal, and started looking for a book she had not read.

She noticed a curio on a shelf that she had never noticed before. "Hello! Where did this one come from?" she wondered. "Where did her mother get the owl from?" She was about to pick it up when the curio opened one eye… It was Owlie pretending to be a curio! 'Mom!' bawled Payal. 'She's back!' 'Don't you ever give me a fright like that again,' she scolded the owl as she put her back in her cage. Payal swore later that Owlie winked back at her. She probably did.

***Vijaya Ghose***